Initiative (BRI) infrastructure plan, pulling Iran into cooperation with China and Pakistan in the development of a new energy infrastructure for West Asia. These developments presented a new challenge to India, to which it has been forced to respond. It did this by joining with Russia and Iran to revive the long-stalled North South Transit corridor, creating a route to the sea for Caspian oil not primarily under Chinese domination.

Yet the period of intense India–China rivalry for Tehran's favour did not last long. Just as post-JCPOA Sino–Indian rivalry was gaining steam, two events occurred that profoundly transformed the regional chessboard: 1) Russian military intervention in Syria starting in September 2014 and in support of Iran's embattled Syrian client Bashar al-Assad and 2) the election of Donald Trump in November 2016, followed by Trump's renunciation of the JCPOA and re-imposition of severe sanctions on Iran and countries that traded with it against US wishes. The re-entry of the two big powers Russia and America created new common interests between India and China while increasing the dangers for both Beijing and New Delhi if they thwarted the wishes and policies of their American and Russian strategic partners. With the two elephants rampaging anew, India and China found some solace in common distance from those two Russian and American behemoths.

The challenge to India presented by the China–Iran strategic partnership is not a hard threat to India's physical security. There is no danger of Iran joining China and/or China's quasi-ally Pakistan in presenting a military threat to India. Rather the threat to India presented by the new (and brief) China–Iran strategic partnership is "soft," involving adverse effects on India's general political and economic position. More specifically, India may find itself confronted by a new dimension of China's growing influence in the Persian Gulf/Arabian Sea region. Closer China–Iran relations could lead to Iran's participation in Beijing's ambitious over-land